considerably, if not entirely, from the Farkhor air base in South Tajikistan (among other places). These facts form credible bedrock for the emphasis of existing studies that India was averse to the pro-Pakistan Taliban. But, why change policy in 1996 when India was open to engaging with pro-Pakistan Afghan factions in 1992? Existing studies emphasise a geostrategic and human rights rationale to this approach. The Taliban was understood, and justly so, as a movement of misogynistic Islamists with a highly questionable approach to human rights. Monotheistic practices as understood by these students of Islam, and often imposed with brute force in practice, gave India space to construe it as an entity with little understanding of matters of statecraft and international diplomacy. This was coupled with a peculiarly strong belief that the Taliban was Islamabad's proxy force.[112] Pakistan's use of militant non-state actors like the Harkat-ul-Ansar (HuA) and the Hizbul Mujahideen (HM) to foment violence in Kashmir buttressed this belief. Fears that the Taliban would support separatism in Kashmir took root, and much more strongly than during the late 1980s and early 1990s. Though credible, this argument does not capture the inherent contradictions in India's policymaking process on Afghanistan.

Firstly, if the anti-Pakistan 'proxy thesis', framed by the idea of realpolitik, were true, then engaging with Taliban would have been within reason. Having gained effective control of more than 60 per cent of Afghan territory by 1997, the Taliban had emerged as a coherent military force dominated by ethnic Pashtuns. Plus, keen on international recognition, the Taliban was cautious before taking an openly anti-India stance. According to declassified intelligence reports used by the US government, HuA militants were being trained in Paktia and Khost by the ISI since mid-1990s.[113] The HuA received between US$ 30,000 to US$ 60,000 per month as aid from the ISI and were also being financed by Al Qaeda.[114] With their fighters sharing camps, ideological affinities between AQ and the HuA grew and HuA leader Fazlul Rahman Khalil started endorsing fatwas that Al Qaeda issued, even to the ISI's consternation.[115] It can be argued that these were the groups that were pivotal in maintaining the momentum of the Kashmir insurgency, and thus, their unchallenged presence in Afghanistan linked the Taliban to Kashmir.